

## Putting **cabbage leaves** on the breast helps soothe and cool down the affected area.

### WHAT YOU CAN DO

- » Check your latching-on technique (see p.268).
- » At the end of a feeding, allow air to get to your nipples so they dry naturally. Try rubbing a couple of drops of breast milk into them, since breast milk has antibacterial properties.
- » Apply a little purified lanolin cream, which is safe to use even before breast-feeding.
- » Avoid breast pads since they keep moisture in.
- » Nipple shields can help but only use them for a short time since they can affect your baby's latch.
- » Don't stop breast-feeding from the sore breast.

- » Continue to breast-feed, checking that he is latched on properly to ensure effective sucking.
- » Babies often suck most strongly at the start of a feeding, so putting your baby on the affected side first may help to drain the milk.
- » Warmth can help your milk flow, so placing a warm washcloth on your breast at the beginning of a feeding may be helpful, and gently massaging your breast can help to reduce swelling.
- » Contact your doctor. He or she can put you in touch with a breast-feeding consultant who can help improve your baby's latch.

- » Contact your doctor right away if you think you have mastitis. If infection has set in, your doctor will prescribe antibiotics that are safe to take while breast-feeding. It's important to keep breast-feeding so that milk is removed regularly and your breasts don't become engorged. You may need to nurse more often than usual, and express milk so that the breast is sufficiently drained.
- » Many women find placing a cold washcloth or chilled cabbage leaf against the breast soothing since these remove heat from the breast.
- » It's important to get plenty of rest.
- » Mild pain relief can help. Ibuprofen also acts as an anti-inflammatory.
- » An abscess that doesn't respond to antibiotics may need to be surgically drained.

## Q My breasts feel as though they're about to burst. Will this last?

**This feeling of fullness, or engorgement, should subside within one or two days.** It's common for women to feel that their breasts have gone up a cup size or two when their milk "comes in," about three to five days after the birth.

In addition to filling with milk, blood flow to the breasts increases during breast-feeding and aside from feeling very full, breasts may feel hot, hard, lumpy, and tender. This engorgement is usually relieved when you nurse your baby and the milk supply starts to settle down.

If the engorgement is uncomfortable, or your baby is finding it hard to latch on, you can hand express or pump a small amount of milk (see p.272) to reduce the fullness just enough to make latching on easier. Be careful not to express too much, though, since you don't want your breasts to make even more milk.

Massaging your breasts a little while your baby nurses may help the milk flow. Or try putting a hot washcloth on your breast or taking a hot shower before feeding to help trigger the letdown reflex. After a feeding, a cold washcloth or compress, or a chilled cabbage leaf, can be soothing and take any heat out of the breast. A properly fitted nursing bra will support your breasts and make them more comfortable; you may want keep a bra on at night too.

## Q My breasts keep leaking milk. How can I deal with this?

**An overabundant milk supply can mean that breasts leak.** This leaking can also happen when your letdown reflex (see p.269) is triggered unexpectedly. Leaking may occur in one breast while you're feeding your baby on the other side, or when you're in a warm environment, such as the shower, or when you hear your baby cry, or even just think about your baby.

Expressing a little milk before or after nursing may reduce leaking, and nursing frequently will ensure that milk is regularly removed and milk production falls into sync with your growing baby's needs. If you sense that you're about to leak milk, discreetly crossing your arms over your chest so that you are putting gentle pressure on your nipples may stem the flow. Putting breast pads inside your bra can contain leaks. Bring spare clothes when you go out.

## Q My baby falls asleep while breast-feeding. What should I do?

**If your baby nods off during a feeding you should gently wake him.** Your baby may come off the breast on his own once he is full, but sometimes babies can fall asleep while on the breast, or continue comfort sucking. If his jaw is no longer moving, or his sucking has become lighter and quicker, but he doesn't appear to be swallowing, he may be full. If this happens, or he falls asleep, gently rouse him and burp him, then check if he wants to continue before ending the session.

## Q My baby cries when he comes off the breast. Am I making enough milk?

**If you breast-feed your baby regularly you will almost certainly be able to make enough milk for him.** Your baby may need more milk for a day or two because he is going through a growth spurt. He may cry as soon as he finishes, or shortly after being fed, and you may feel like you're breast-feeding continuously.

If you meet your baby's increased demands, your supply will increase to meet his needs. Offering both breasts at each feeding will help your milk supply increase more rapidly, and you might even need to keep switching breasts until your baby seems completely satisfied.

The clearest sign that your baby is feeding well and thriving is that he is gaining weight. Being nice and alert when awake, and having more than six wet diapers a day are also sure signs that your baby is well-nourished. Talk to your pediatrician if you have any concerns.

## Q I have inverted nipples. Will this prevent me from breast-feeding?

**It is possible to breast-feed if your nipples are inverted, but you will need some guidance.** A breast-feeding consultant can check how you are managing to feed. She may recommend using a breast pump to draw out the nipple before you begin feeding, or using a nipple shield to help the baby latch on. Pulling the breast tissue back as your baby latches on will also help the nipple to protrude. Seek advice from your doctor if you are finding it hard.